

Late surge: This was Lewis Hamilton's second victory in three races, taking him to sixth in driver standings. AFP

a distant threat. As Norris made up time on his new tyres, he pipped Piastri, who was left out on worn tyres, before stopping two laps later.

McLaren promised Piastri that Norris would give up the position, but things got complicated when the latter refused to do so immediately. Piastri led the race by two seconds before the pit stop but fell six seconds behind Norris through no fault of his own.

Following a series of messages from the pit wall that went from pleading to something slightly more stern, Norris slowed dramatically on the pit straight to let his teammate get back into the lead.

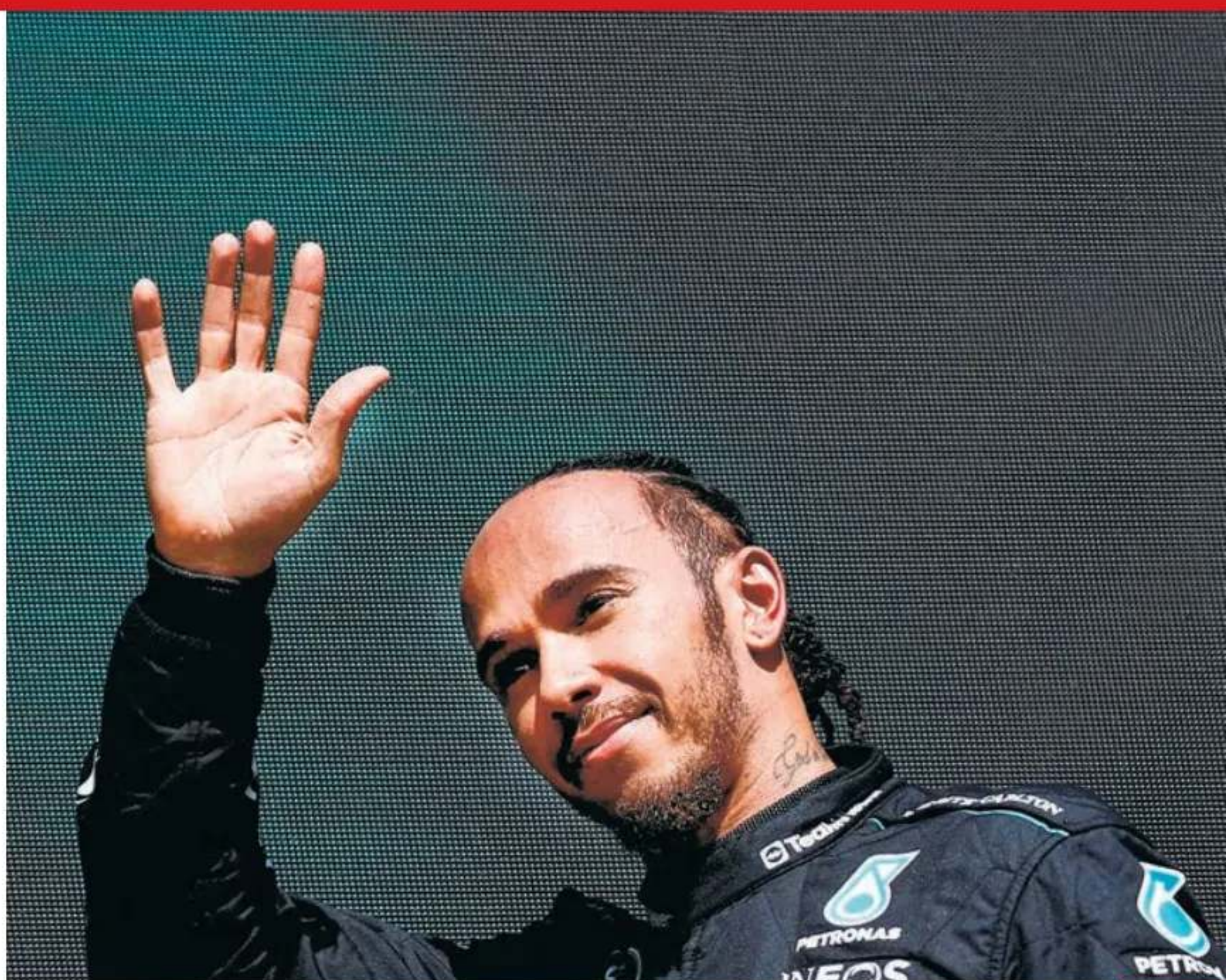
The Aussie eventually took the chequered flag, but not in the way he would have envisioned for his maiden Grand Prix win. Norris' shenanigans and the team's overcautious approach eventually overshadowed a measured drive from the 23-year-old. The win made Piastri (**below**) the first driver born in the 21st century to win a Grand Prix, and the triumph should be the first of many for the Melburnian.

Elation turns to dismay

After McLaren's 1-2 in Hungary, Mercedes achieved the same feat in Belgium when the chequered flag fell at the iconic Spa-Francorchamps. However, the German marque's celebrations were short-lived.

Verstappen and Red Bull were back on pace, taking pole position. But the team's decision to take a 10-grid penalty for using a fifth engine on the defending champion's car meant he had to start 11th. Up front, Hamilton got into the lead on the third lap, passing Charles Leclerc, who inherited pole position. After the first round of stops, Hamilton led from Leclerc, followed by Piastri and George Russell in the other Mercedes.

The seven-time champion was in complete control of the race and was rarely threatened by the Ferrari. At the second stop,



Hamilton, Leclerc, and Piastri took new tyres, but Russell stayed out, trying to finish the race without stopping again.

It was a brave call, but it also made sense, considering that had he stopped, he would have, at best, finished fourth or fifth.

So the stage was set for Hamilton to breeze past his teammate on his new tyres.

Russell's battle was whether he would have enough life left in his tyres to repel an attack from Leclerc, who was overtaken by Piastri, to salvage a third-place finish.

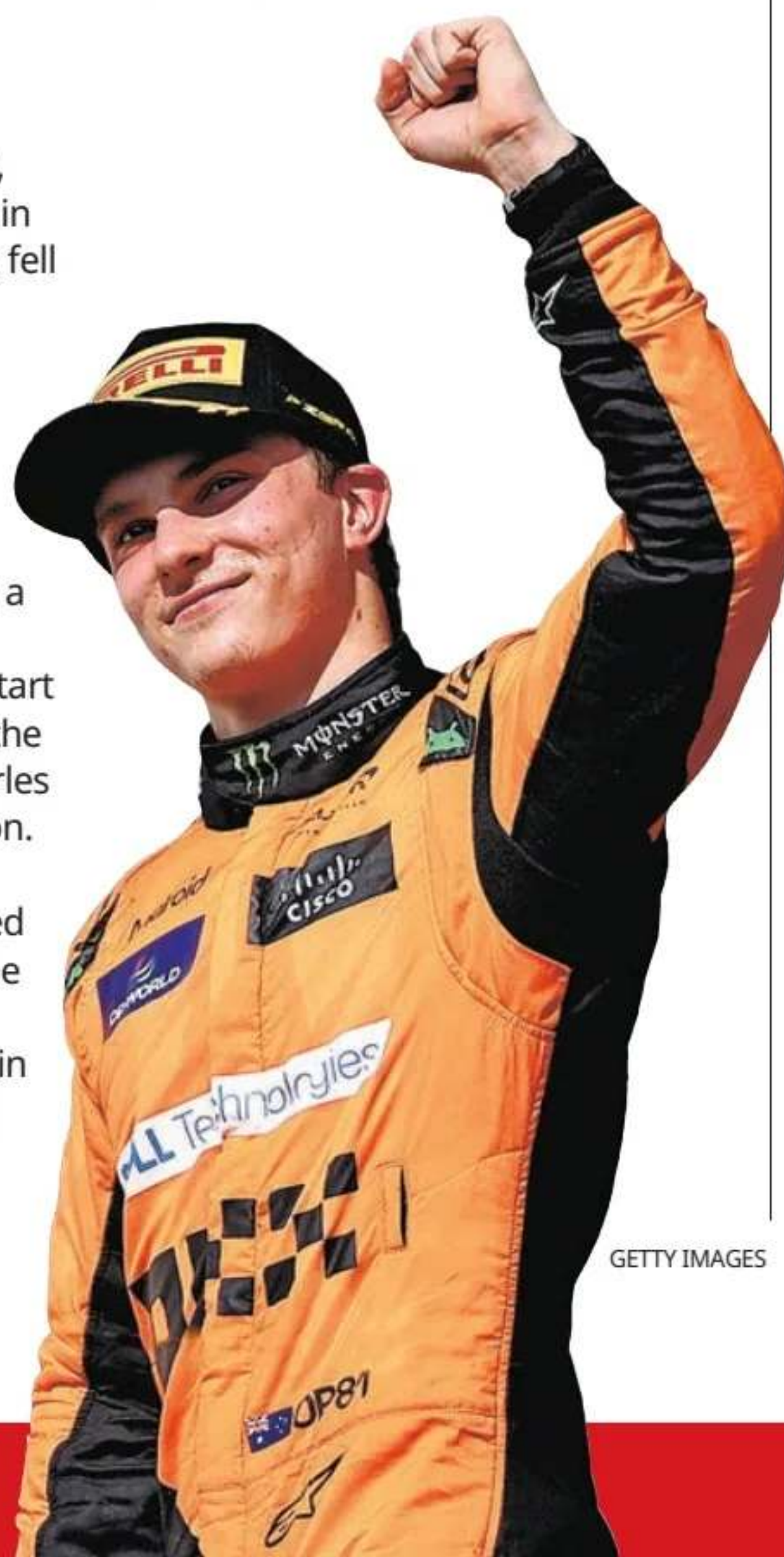
But the British driver, who started sixth, did a tremendous job of staying ahead, keeping Hamilton and Piastri at bay in the closing stages.

Russell eventually crossed the line ahead of Hamilton and Piastri, and the top three were covered by just 1.5 seconds.

It was probably Russell's finest drive, but that ecstasy quickly fizzled into disappointment when stewards found his car 1.5 kg below the minimum weight limit at the post-race scrutineering.

Russell was disqualified from the race, and Hamilton inherited the win. In a quirk of fate, the one-stopper might have contributed to Russell's disqualification, as he burned a lot of rubber by going long and could have led to his car being under the weight limit.

In Austria, Russell was gifted a victory when Norris and Verstappen collided. In Spa, the gods of fate took one away from him.



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